

LEGAL ALIEN

Final Project Proposal For Immersive Experiences Summer 2025 by Abrar Almari



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CONCEPT

Using the absurdity, humor, and mundanity of 'becoming' an alien student to Earth and embodying their home routine for a larger commentary on immigration, visas, being 'legal' or 'illegal' in the United States, and the surrounding fear and anxiety of status.

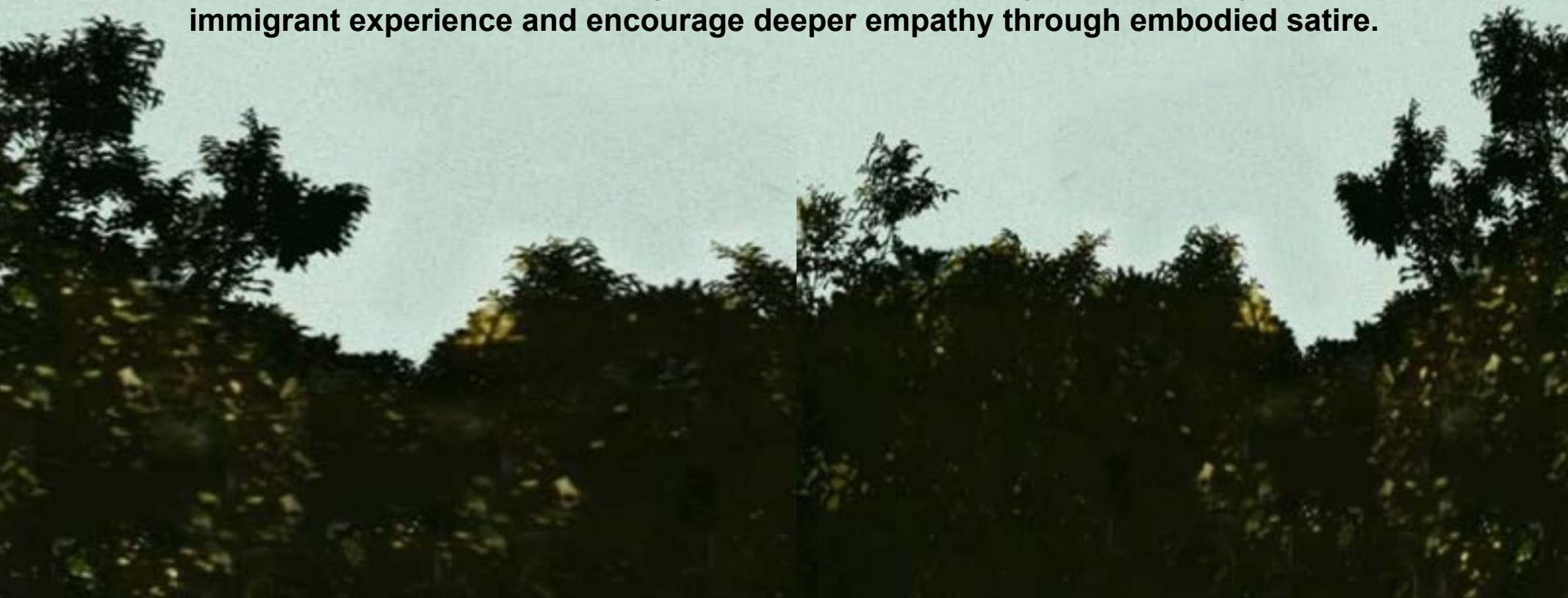
A composite image featuring a classic UFO abduction scene. A saucer-shaped spacecraft hovers in a pale, overcast sky, emitting a powerful, white, conical beam of light. Within this beam, a small, dark silhouette of a person stands with arms slightly outstretched. The beam originates from a dense, dark line of trees at the bottom of the frame. The overall tone is surreal and evocative, serving as a visual metaphor for the concept of immigration discussed in the text.

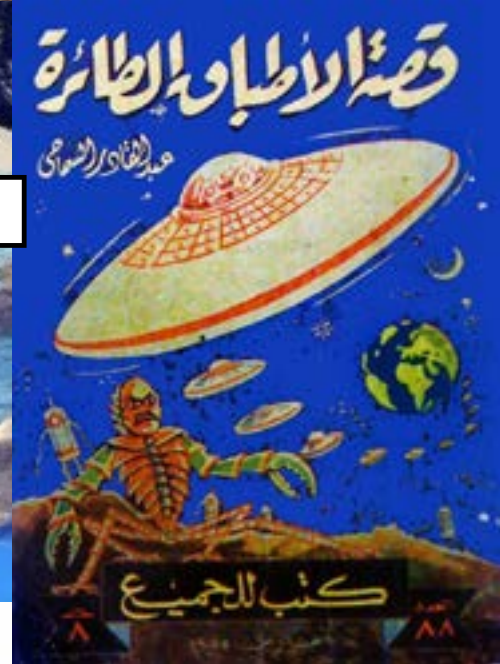
**I WANT
TO LEAVE**

CONCEPT

Through the juxtaposition of sci-fi aesthetics and the painful banality of real-world forms, paperwork, and domestic uncertainty, Legal Alien presents an uncanny reflection of what it means to be “illegal,” “in process,” or simply misunderstood. It seeks to provoke critical reflection on national belonging, surveillance, assimilation, and bureaucratic cruelty.

This experience is designed for VR festivals, digital art exhibitions, and academic showcases, particularly those interested in migration, identity politics, speculative fiction, or post-colonial media. It also aims to reach non-immigrant audiences who may not viscerally understand the immigrant experience and encourage deeper empathy through embodied satire.





VISUAL STYLE

ONBOARDING

- 👤 The onboarding experience will begin at the old TWA terminal at JFK.
- 👤 Participants will be handed their alien passports and asked to disembark from their plane and go through US customs and border patrol.
- 👤 They will then enter a second room to begin the VR portion to truly 'become' an alien



STORY

- ☛ **Morning:** Wake in dorm, attend virtual immigration check-in before class. If the alien's camera fails to load, they're warned their status may be "under review."
- ☛ **Classes:** Manage attention as professors speak while making sure you are interpreting/translating it correctly, submitting assignments on time and keeping grades up.
- ☛ **Midday:** Attempt to work a campus job in the dining hall (as allowed), but face interruptions for ID verification.
- ☛ **Afternoon:** A "random" immigration status audit forces the alien to skip lab, risking academic probation.
- ☛ **Evening:** Socialize at the "Global Student Mixer," where NPCs ask microaggressive questions like "Wow, do you dream in English?" or "Is your planet safe?"
- ☛ **Climax:** Midterms coincide with a Department of Homeland Security email stating the alien must "update biometrics in person by tomorrow." The player must navigate a surreal, bureaucratic maze (literally) while trying to make it to the mid-term on time.
- ☛ **Ending:** The semester ends with an ambiguous notice: "Congratulations, you have been automatically enrolled for another semester... pending compliance review." The cycle restarts.

GAME MECHANISMS

💡 **Core Meters:** Academic Standing, Visa Compliance, Social Adaptation.

💡 **Possible Mini-Games:**

- **Lecture Focus:** Take notes while swatting away visual distractions (buzzing phones, alien hallucinations).
- **Form F-1.42 Completion:** Timed drag-and-stamp puzzle where forms glitch mid-fill.
- **Dining Hall Job:** Serve food in sequence, avoid dropping trays while random ID checks occur.
- **Cultural Conversation:** Choose correct timing and tone in dialogue to avoid awkwardness or suspicion.
- **Status Audit Chase:** Locate scattered documents across campus before timer runs out.
- **Random Events:** Portal crashes, rule changes, professor absences, surprise parties (boost social but risk compliance).
- **Win/Lose Conditions:** Survive semester with all meters above thresholds → advance to harder semester. Any meter hitting zero triggers humorous/tragic “status failure” scene.

💡 **Replayability:** Procedurally generated semesters with new professors, roommates, and visa challenges. Unlockable cosmetic alien accessories for long survival streaks.

TECHNICAL APPROACH

👽 Engine: Unity (URP for standalone VR, HDRP for PC builds).

👽 VR Platforms: Oculus Quest 2 (via Link) + SteamVR PC support.

👽 Core Tools:

👽 Unity XR Interaction Toolkit for object handling and form-filling interactions.

👽 Ink/Fungus for dialogue branching.

👽 Optimization: Occlusion culling, baked lighting, adaptive LOD for stable VR performance.

👽 Team Requirements: Game Designer / Writer, 3D Artist, Animator, Unity VR Developer, Sound Designer / Composer, Project Manager / Producer QA Tester

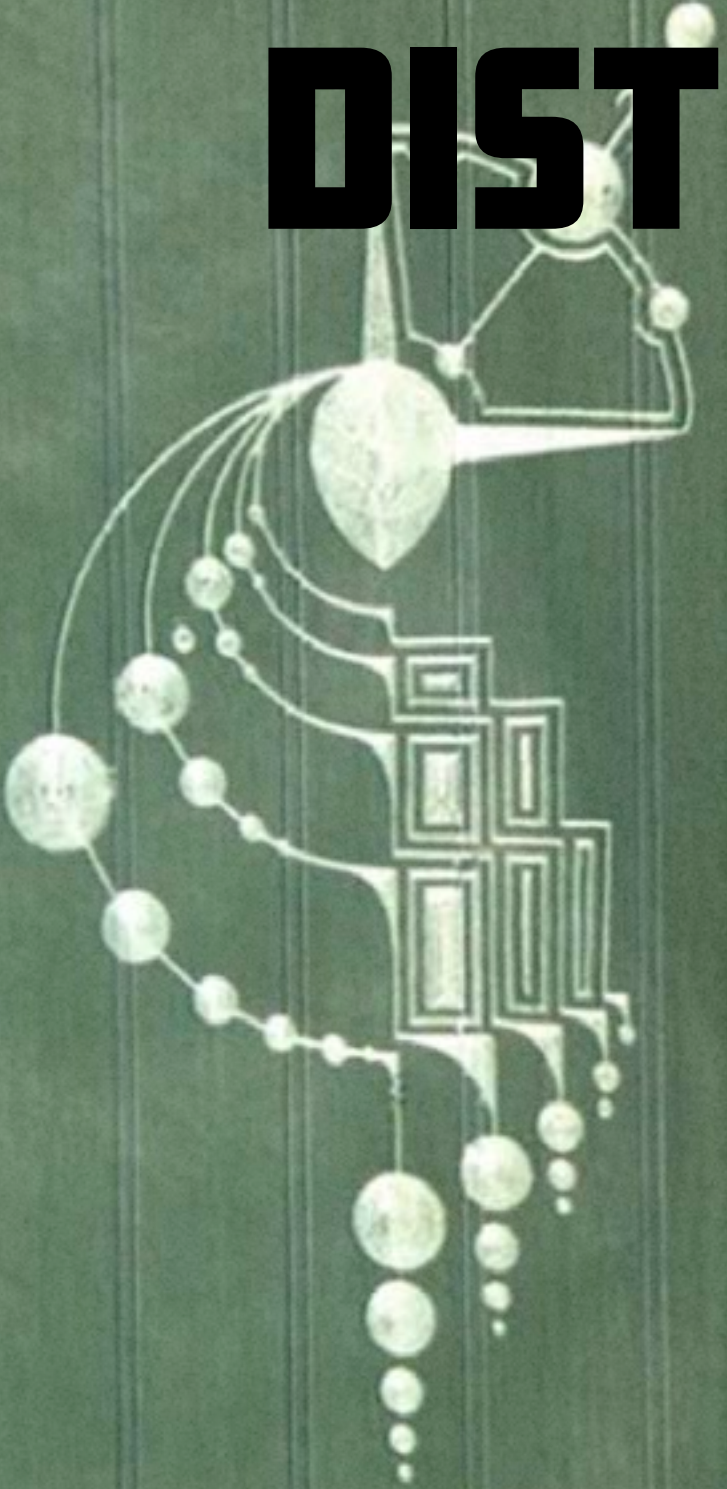


OFFBOARDING

📍 Participants will be guided from the VR experience to the check in counters of TWA where they will pick up their 'tickets' home, go through TSA and a 'special' security screening, and board their flight back 'home'.



DISTRIBUTION



👁 Exhibitions:

- VR art and storytelling festivals (Venice VR, Tribeca Immersive).
- Education and policy conferences on migration and higher education.
- Campus-based screenings in international student advocacy spaces.

👁 Digital Platforms:

- SteamVR and SideQuest for direct player access.
- Itch.io for art/game community distribution.

👁 Promotion:

- Satirical “University Welcome” trailers.
- Social campaigns featuring short clips of alien student life (“First Day of Class on Earth,” “Campus Job Struggles”).

don't worry.
i believe in you.

AUTHOR'S NOTE